

Functional Dependencies and Normalisation

txt2tex example

May 22, 2026

$[EmpID, EmpName, DeptName, HeadName, ProjID, ProjName]$

The Universal Relation

We start with a single unnormalised relation that bundles every attribute together. The composite primary key is (empID, projID) – an employee can be assigned to many projects, and a project involves many employees.

Universal

empID : EmpID
empName : EmpName
dept : DeptName
deptHead : HeadName
projID : ProjID
projName : ProjName

$PK(Universal) = \{empID, projID\}$

The relation is in 1NF: every attribute is single-valued and every row is uniquely identified by (empID, projID).

Functional Dependencies

We identify the following functional dependencies (FDs).

Full-key dependency (no issue):

$empID, projID \rightarrow empName, dept, deptHead, projName$

Partial dependencies – empName, dept, and deptHead depend on empID alone; projName depends on projID alone. These violate 2NF.

$empID \rightarrow empName, dept, deptHead$ $projID \rightarrow projName$

Transitive dependency – deptHead is determined by dept, not directly by empID. This violates 3NF even after removing the partial dependencies.

$dept \rightarrow deptHead$

2NF: Remove Partial Dependencies

A relation is in 2NF when every non-key attribute depends on the whole primary key, not just part of it. We remove empName, dept, deptHead (which depend only on empID) and projName (which depends only on projID) into their own relations.

Remaining composite relation after 2NF lift – empID and projID are the composite primary key; all remaining attributes depend on the full key:

EmpProj2NF(empID, projID)

Employee attributes extracted into a separate relation:

EmpDept2NF(empID, empName, dept, deptHead)

Project attributes extracted into a separate relation:

Proj2NF(projID, projName)

EmpDept2NF is still not in 3NF: $dept \rightarrow deptHead$ is a transitive dependency. deptHead is a fact about the department, not the employee.

3NF: Remove Transitive Dependencies

A relation is in 3NF when every non-key attribute depends directly on the primary key and on nothing else. We remove deptHead (determined by dept) into a Department relation and drop it from EmployeeProj.

Final 3NF decomposition – four relations:

Employee

empID : EmpID
empName : EmpName
dept : DeptName

PK(Employee) = {*empID*}

Department

dept : DeptName
deptHead : HeadName

PK(Department) = {*dept*}

Project

projID : ProjID
projName : ProjName

PK(Project) = {*projID*}

Assignment

empID : EmpID
projID : ProjID

PK(Assignment) = {*empID*, *projID*}

Every non-key attribute now depends only on its own primary key. No partial or transitive dependencies remain. The decomposition is lossless: rejoining Employee, Department, Assignment, and Project on their shared keys reconstructs the original Universal relation exactly.